

EVERYDAY MILLIONAIRE

Jack was born right after World War II and was raised in a blue-collar family. Jack's father and grandfather were both steel mill factory workers, and the family never had much money. He said he was raised to believe that most people don't have money and those who do should be extremely grateful and wise in managing it—advice he still values to this day. Seeing his family struggle with money motivated Jack to get a quality education. That motivation paid off, as he was the first in his family to go to college, graduating with a degree in mathematics. There was no nepotism or family money involved in his school selections. He set his sights on where he wanted to go, and he busted his butt to get the grades and tuition money he needed. Not surprisingly, this go-getter got a great job right out of school, but he was drafted and sent to Vietnam six months later.

Jack served as an Army officer during the Vietnam War, and he was determined to bring every one of the people serving under him back in one piece. He did. After the war, he took that determination back into the workforce, taking a position with a large technology company. He stayed at that one company for the rest of his career, racking up promotions and having the chance to try new things every few years. At his leadership peak, he led two hundred and fifty people and managed a \$250 million budget.

As Jack's income grew, he stayed faithful to the investing plan he and his financial advisor drafted when he returned from Vietnam at age twenty-eight. Throughout his thirty-two-year career, his motto was, "With every paycheck, pay yourself first for the future." He did exactly that, investing into company retirement plans, taking advantage of matching dollars, managing risk, and keeping a watchful eye over his diversified portfolio. As a result, Jack was able to retire at age fifty with a current net worth of over \$2 million. He now spends his days traveling, picking up odd jobs for fun, spending time with his kids and grandkids, and volunteering in his community.

Looking back on his life, Jack knows that his education was the thing that enabled him to change his family's financial legacy. He's grateful for the educational opportunities he had, and he knows those opportunities are there for anyone. If someone from a poor, blue-collar, steel mill background can do it, anyone can. Of course, he made sure his two children prioritized their educations as well, and now his son runs a private biochemistry lab, and his daughter is a teacher. "Education is really important," he said, "and can really help someone build wealth."

Jack's education gave him an advantage in his career, but he had to work hard for that education. Nobody gave it to him, and no one forced him into it. His father and grandfather would have welcomed him at the steel mill, but Jack had different plans for his life. So he gave *himself* the advantage he